

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN TRINIDAD AND TOBAGO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide uses the terms and bodies you'll actually run into in Trinidad and Tobago — the Certificate of Environmental Clearance, the EMA, the EIA and public comment, the health-and-pollution case, the courts — and explains each in plain words the first time.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In 2006 the world's largest aluminium producer signed a deal to build a vast **smelter** — a project of around **one and a half billion US dollars** — at **Chatham and Cap-de-Ville**, on the southwest peninsula of Trinidad, a coast of fishing villages, mangroves, and coconut estates that had already watched liquefied-gas plants rise and the fish grow scarce. The communities said no. Farmers and fishers, Indo- and Afro-Trinidadian, joined with environmentalists, scientists, and activists; they held all-night vigils outside the Prime Minister's office, marched, rallied, and kept a **round-the-clock camp at the site to block the soil tests and the bulldozers**. By the end of 2006 the government dropped the Cap-de-Ville smelter; by 2008 the company withdrew from the country altogether, its own records showing it feared the people's hostility; and by 2010 a second smelter planned at La Brea was scrapped as well. Two smelters that would have poisoned the peninsula's air and water were stopped by the people who lived there — in a country built on oil, gas, and heavy industry.

The coastal communities of Chatham and Cap-de-Ville — fishers, farmers, and their allies, Indo- and Afro-Trinidadian together — drew on tools that work even in a petro-state driven toward heavy industry. A major project needs a **Certificate of Environmental Clearance (CEC)** from the **Environmental Management Authority (EMA)**, often on the basis of an **EIA** with public comment. The **health-and-pollution case** — fluoride, emissions, cancer, asthma, ruined fisheries — is a powerful argument. The **courts** are open; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. And the nation's attention, in a small and vocal country, is a real lever. What made the smelter fight work was above all **unity across the lines that so often divide** — the peninsula's mixed villages, whom a promise of jobs might have set against one another, held together around a shared refusal to bear the poison. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The victory came in **stages, over years**, and leaned partly on forces beyond the community — a **global recession** that cooled the company's appetite, and a **change of government** that scrapped the second smelter — not on protest alone. Trinidad and Tobago is a **petro-state**, structurally driven toward heavy industry, with a powerful energy lobby and a real hunger for the jobs such projects promise, so the pressure never fully ends. And the communities were **not always united** — some, desperate for work, wanted the smelter — so a campaign against heavy industry in a place that needs jobs cannot dismiss that hope; it must answer it honestly with the true costs to health and livelihood.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of approvals, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A large Trinagonian project needs its **CEC** from the EMA (and, usually, an **EIA** with public comment); it must survive the **health-and-pollution case**; it can be challenged in the **courts**; and it depends on public

acquiescence a **united community and the nation's attention** can strip away. Every one of those is a link you can grab. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If it's a polluting heavy-industry project, the health-and-pollution case is your sharpest argument** — fluoride, emissions, cancer, asthma, ruined fisheries move people and courts.
- **If it needs a CEC or EIA, that clearance process and its public comment are real levers.**
- **If your community is mixed, unity across the divides is the whole game** — a jobs promise can split you, and a split community loses.
- **If the petro-state and the energy lobby are behind it, expect a staged, years-long fight** — aim for a dropped or scrapped project, a refused CEC, delay, and a turned nation, and hold your people together.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **unite across the divides and hold the ground** — the community, the camp, the health case, the nation — and **run every front at once**: the documents, the clearance process, the courts, the coalition, the country. That's how the smelters were stopped.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The core decision is the **Certificate of Environmental Clearance (CEC)**, issued by the **EMA**, often after an **EIA** with public comment. Planning and sector bodies grant the land and project permissions. The **courts** review the legality of clearances and decisions. And in a small, vocal democracy, the **government** is unusually sensitive to sustained public pressure and the nation's mood. Know which decision you can contest, and aim there.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The EIA and public comment. A major project prepares an EIA; there's public comment. *Your opening — and it arms every later step*: comment, put your objections and the health case on the record.

The CEC. The EMA grants or refuses the clearance. *Your opening*: a CEC on a defective EIA, or against the health evidence, is vulnerable to challenge.

Site works and construction. *Your opening — the one that worked at Chatham*: a sustained presence at the site can physically block soil tests and bulldozers, buying time; and breaches are challengeable.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who owns them** — including any foreign company, whose reputation and appetite you can affect. **What it still needs** — the CEC not granted or under challenge, the EIA not approved, the site not secured: whatever's missing is the soft spot. **What health harm it brings** — because the health-and-pollution case is your strongest argument.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **EMA** grants and oversees the CEC. The **courts** review clearances. Health and environmental authorities hold evidence. And Trinidad and Tobago's **fishing and farming communities, environmental organisations, scientists, and a vocal press** are the forces that reach furthest — the coalition that stopped the smelters.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether the health case is strong, whether the community stays united, whether the nation turns, and how determined the petro-state is.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Comment / health case in the EIA	15–35%	during EIA	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Challenge the CEC (courts)	25–50%	months–yr	mod	Clearance quashed; process ordered
Site presence / camp (block the works)	25–50%	ongoing	low	Works blocked; time bought (Chatham)
Health-and-pollution campaign	30–55%	months–yr	low	Public and government turned
United coalition across divides	30–55%	months–yr	low	Broad, hard-to-split pressure
Turn the nation's attention	30–55%	months–yr	low	Political cost; project dropped
Everything together (health case, united, nation turned)	40–65%	1–4 yr	mod	Dropped, scrapped, refused, delayed
Everything together (petro-state priority, split community)	20–45%	1–4 yr	mod	Delayed; staged; exposed

The levers that move the needle most are the **health-and-pollution case**, a **united community holding the ground**, and **turning the nation**, backed by the clearance process and the courts. Chatham shows the ceiling (two smelters stopped) and the honest floor (staged over years, helped by a recession and a change of government, in a petro-state that keeps pushing). So aim for a project dropped or scrapped, a refused CEC, delay, and a turned nation — and hold your people together.

On cost: commenting, campaigning, and a site presence are cheap; the strength is people and unity, not money. The great danger is a jobs promise that splits a mixed community — so answer it honestly and hold your people together, because a fight that loses its own hungry has already half lost.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this health harm, this defective CEC, this divided village — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who's behind it? Name the project, the company, any foreign parent, and the financiers whose appetite you can affect.

2. Where is it, and what does it touch? Map it over homes, air, water, fishing grounds, mangroves, and farmland. **A heavy-polluting project's threat to health and fisheries is your sharpest lever** — Chatham's people feared the fluoride, the cancer, the ruined waters.

3. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline? Is an EIA in public comment? Has the CEC issued (opening a court challenge)? Are site works (soil tests) starting (the moment to hold the ground)? These openings are time-bound.

4. What does it still need that it lacks? The CEC not final, the EIA not approved, the site not secured. The missing piece is the soft spot.

5. Is your community united, and who else is affected? Mixed villages, fishers and farmers, environmentalists, scientists — and where jobs might split you. Chatham's strength was unity across Indo- and Afro-Trinidadian, farming and fishing families.

What this looks like in real life. A coastal community learns a smelter or petrochemical plant will poison its air and waters, with a jobs promise dangled to divide it. The five questions yield: a company and foreign parent; a grave health-and-fisheries harm (the lever); an EIA or CEC in process; a site to hold; and a mixed community to unite. That's the Chatham pattern — make the health case, hold the ground, and unite across the divides.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof — and Chatham's was the health science. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the paper trail. Get the documents the decision rests on — the EIA, the CEC and conditions, the emissions data, the company's records. Then read the EIA hard for flaws — understated fluoride and emissions, ignored health impacts, dismissed effects on fisheries.

Layer two: the health and ground truth. Marshal the **health-and-pollution science** — the fluoride, the emissions, the cancer and asthma risk, the harm to fish-breeding waters — and gather dated, located photographs of the coast, mangroves, and fishing grounds, and the testimony of fishers and residents. The health case is your strongest weapon.

Layer three: the map of harm. Lay the project over your homes, air, water, and fishing grounds, so the poison it would spread is undeniable. Walking into the EMA, the courts, or the nation with the health science, the EIA flaws, and that map is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The EIA, the CEC and conditions, the emissions data** — from the EMA and the health/environmental authorities.
- **The health-and-pollution science** — on fluoride, emissions, cancer, asthma, and fisheries harm.
- **Ownership and financing** — the company, its parent, and financiers.
- **The harm map** — homes, air, water, and fishing grounds, laid over the project.

- **Dated site evidence and named testimony** — photographs marked with date and place, and fishers' and residents' statements.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a united community holding the ground gives you power — the Chatham template. Build in four moves.

Unite across the divides first. Chatham's whole strength was holding together a mixed community — Indo- and Afro-Trinidadian, fishers and farmers — around a shared refusal to bear the poison. Answer the jobs promise honestly, point toward safer prosperity, and hold your people together, because a split community loses.

Bind the community to experts and activists. Add environmentalists and scientists who can make the health case, and activists from the towns who can carry the fight to the capital. Chatham joined the peninsula's people to a wider movement.

Hold the ground. A round-the-clock **camp at the site** turned back Chatham's soil-testing crews and bulldozers, buying the time the legal and political fight needed. Plan any such presence collectively and with legal advice, non-violently.

Build to last, and turn the nation. Trinbagonian fights run for years against a petro-state. Build clear roles, a secure shared archive, a way to decide together, a plan for the toll — and a strategy to make the whole small nation take notice, because the nation's attention is a decisive lever.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES & THE HEALTH CASE

Trinidad and Tobago's sharpest levers are the health case, the clearance process, and — where needed — the courts.

The Health-and-Pollution Case

Your strongest argument is **health and pollution**: the fluoride and emissions of a smelter, the cancer and asthma, the ruin of fish-breeding waters. Marshal the science, put it on the record in the EIA public comment, and make it the heart of the campaign and any court challenge — it moves people, the government, and judges, and it unites a mixed community around a shared danger.

The CEC, the EIA, and the Courts

Take part in the **EIA public comment**; a **CEC** granted on a defective EIA or against the health evidence can be challenged in the **courts**, which can quash the clearance or order the process redone. The clearance process is the project's formal gateway — and its defects are your legal opening.

Holding the Ground

The distinctive Chatham lever: a sustained, non-violent **site presence** that physically blocks soil tests and construction, buying time for the legal and political fight. Plan it collectively, with legal advice, and pair it always with the health case and the courts.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: the health case, the clearance process, and the courts are real levers, but the petro-state keeps pushing, wins come in stages over years, and outside forces (a recession, a change of government) helped at Chatham. So use the strong tools — the health case, the EIA and CEC, the courts, the site presence — pair them with a united community and a turned nation, and count a project dropped or scrapped, a refused CEC, delay, and exposure as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Emissions become a health emergency. Not "we oppose the smelter" but *"this will spread fluoride and emissions over our homes — cancer, asthma, and the ruin of the waters we fish."*

A defective CEC becomes a court challenge. *"The EIA understated the health harm — the clearance is unlawful."*

A jobs promise becomes an honest answer. *"We need work, but not poison — and there are safer paths to prosperity than a smelter that sickens our children."*

The harm becomes a national story. *"A coast of fishing villages and coconut estates, poisoned for a foreign smelter — in a country that already carries enough heavy industry."*

Match it to the venue: the health case to the EIA and the nation; the defective CEC to the courts; the jobs answer to your own community; the national story to the press.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Trinidad and Tobago, the nation's attention is a decisive lever — the small, vocal country can be turned — and international attention affects a foreign company's appetite. A vocal press makes the media front central.

Lead with health and the coast, not procedure. Not "the CEC was defective" but "a coast of fishing villages poisoned for a foreign smelter — cancer, asthma, and ruined waters." Use your strongest material: the health science, dated photographs, the map, fishers' voices, and any court action or site stand banked.

Work several audiences at once. Local and national press turn the nation; international media and networks affect the foreign company's appetite and reputation, where it's most exposed (Chatham's company feared the hostility). Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, a map, strong interviews.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything, especially on health science. And protect people and unity — plan any site presence with legal advice, and let the whole community shape the story.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Information request (to the EMA).

Subject: Request for the CEC and EIA — [project].

"We, residents of [place], request the EIA, the Certificate of Environmental Clearance and conditions, and the emissions data for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Health case / objection in the EIA comment.

Subject: Objection — EIA for [project].

"We, residents of [place], object to [project]: [it spreads fluoride and emissions over our homes; it threatens cancer, asthma, and our fisheries; the EIA understates the harm]. We ask that clearance be refused. [Attach the health evidence.]"

8C — To the EMA (the clearance).

Subject: Concerns re the CEC for [project].

"We ask the EMA to refuse or condition the CEC for [project], on the health-and-pollution evidence and the EIA's defects. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — To a lawyer (court challenge).

Subject: Possible challenge — [project] CEC.

"Our community faces [project], whose CEC rests on a defective EIA and ignores grave health harm. We've gathered [the EIA, the health science, photographs]. We ask your advice on challenging the clearance in the courts. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8E — To your own community (unity / the jobs question).

Subject: Jobs, yes — but not poison.

"We all need work, and this project dangles it. But a smelter would poison our air, our water, and our children's health, and ruin the waters we fish. Let's stand together — across all our villages — and demand a safer path to prosperity. [Contact.]"

8F — To the company / its investors.

Subject: Health, legal, and reputational risk in [project].

"We are the community affected by [project] at [location]. It threatens grave health harm and faces sustained opposition and legal challenge. As at Chatham, this carries real reputational and commercial risk. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press.

Subject: [Community] moves to protect its coast and health from [project].

"The people of [place] have fished and farmed [this coast] for generations. Now [project] threatens [our air, our water, our health]. We can provide the health science, photographs, a map and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the community.

Subject: We can protect our coast — here's how.

"[Project] threatens [our air, water, and health]. At Chatham, a mixed community united across every divide, made the health case, held the ground, and turned the nation — and stopped two smelters. With the same unity, we have a real chance. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Unite your community across every divide, and answer the jobs promise honestly (8E/8H).** Unity is the whole game.
2. **Make the health-and-pollution case, and put it in the EIA comment (8B).**
3. **Request the documents (8A), and read the EIA for health-harm flaws.**
4. **Photograph everything, with dates and places, and marshal the health science.**
5. **Hold the ground at the site if works begin — planned, collective, non-violent.**
6. **Get a lawyer for a CEC challenge (8D), and turn the nation (8G).**

Even lean, those six unite the community, make the health case, hold the ground, and turn the country — the Chatham template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Trinidad and Tobago's tools are real, but the petro-state tilts the field, and you must plan for it.

When the energy lobby and the state push. Don't fold: make the health case, hold the ground, turn the nation, and use the courts — and aim for a dropped or scrapped project, delay, and a turned public.

When jobs split your community. This is the central danger. Answer the hope honestly with the true costs, point toward safer prosperity, and hold your people together — a split community loses.

When the win comes in stages. Chatham took years and outside help. Keep the coalition alive through each stage, and be ready for the project to return in another form or place.

When outside forces help — or don't. A recession and a change of government helped at Chatham; don't count on them. Build a campaign strong enough to win on its own, and take the help when it comes.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Trinidad and Tobago has real concerns about the closeness of the energy and industrial lobby to decisions, so this matters.

How to spot it. Clearances against the health evidence; an EIA written for the proponent; deals done for the lobby; benefits to the connected while communities bear the poison.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **Auditor General** examines public money. The **Integrity Commission** handles official conduct. The **courts** can quash a tainted CEC. And Trinidad and Tobago's **press and environmental organisations** have exposed captured projects.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how the clearance was bent, who benefits, what the health evidence showed — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the Auditor General, the Integrity Commission, the courts, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the health case and the legal challenge.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documents and health science build your proof; the health case aims it; a united community holding the ground is the muscle; the EIA, the CEC, and the courts press the case; the nation's attention raises the cost. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and be ready for the fight to return.

Early on (weeks 1–8): unite the community and answer the jobs question; marshal the health science; object in the EIA; request the records; photograph the baseline; build a coalition of community, experts, and activists.

In the thick of it (months–years): challenge a defective CEC in the courts; hold the ground at the site if works begin; turn the nation with the health case.

The long haul (years): carry the campaign and litigation through each stage; keep the community united and the nation engaged; hold the line for a project dropped or scrapped, a refused CEC, delay — and watch for its return.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Trinidad and Tobago can be done — a mixed coastal community, united across every divide, stopped two aluminium smelters in a country built on heavy industry. Hold both truths. Trinidad and Tobago's tools are real: a CEC and EIA process with public comment; a powerful health-and-pollution argument; open courts; and a small, vocal nation that can be turned. And the constraints are real: a petro-state driven toward heavy industry, a powerful energy lobby, staged wins that lean partly on outside forces, and a jobs promise that can split a community.

Here's the discipline that wins. Unite your community across every divide, and answer the jobs promise honestly — because a split community loses. Make the health-and-pollution case the heart of everything: the fluoride, the emissions, the cancer and asthma, the ruined waters. Put it in the EIA comment, challenge a defective CEC in the courts, and — if the works begin — hold the ground with a planned, non-violent site presence, as Chatham did. Turn the whole small nation, and take the fight to a foreign company's reputation and appetite. Count a project dropped or scrapped, a refused CEC, delay, and a turned nation as wins, and stay vigilant for its return. That's what Chatham did — the unity, the camp, the health case, and the nation together. So can you.